The Second Phase

Meanwhile India was celebrating its success of the first phase, a new challenge confronted India—achieving ***economic access*** to food. The situation went on worsening and by early 2000 there was a paradoxical situation in the country when it was having more than three times buffer stocks of foodgrains in the central pool but in several states people were dying due to lack of food—a complete mockery of the logic behind maintaining buffer stock, success of green revolution and the concept of India being a welfare state[12] ! The Supreme Court intervened after a PIL was filed by the People's Union for Civil Liberties (PUCL) and a national level Food for Work Programme came up (to be merged with the National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme now). The courts took the governments on task if foodgrains rot either in godowns or destroyed in oceans to manage market price for the foodgrains, or if the centre had to go for exporting wheat at very low price. In this process India emerged as the ***seventh largest*** exporter of wheat (2002)! Basically, we were exporting the share of wheat which was not consumed by many Indians due to lack of economic reach to the food.

As the inputs of the Green Revolution were costlier, its output naturally were to be costlier. To fight the situation there should have been a time-bound and target-oriented macro-economic policy support which could deliver comparative increase in the purchasing capacity of the masses to make the food affordable for them. India badly failed in it. The crisis was managed by throwing higher and higher subsidies ultimately affecting government expenditure on the infrastructural shortcomings in the agriculture sector. Even after providing higher food subsidies, some people failed to purchase food and they were left with no option but to die of hunger!

India is still in this phase and trying to solve the crisis through twin approach firstly, by creating maximum number of gainful employment and secondly by cutting cost of the foodgrains (via the second green revolution based on the biotechnology).

It must be kept in mind that the food self-sufficiency happiness was a temporary thing for India. By the mid 1990s, India realised that its